

Title: A comparative analysis of Mauryan Monarchy and Athenian Democracy: Governance in Ancient Worlds

Introduction

The systems of governance in ancient societies did not only act as means of control but were an interior manifestation of cultural beliefs, religious beliefs and philosophical principles. The analysis of two organizational systems of government, the monarchist Mauryan Empire of ancient India and the democratic polis of Athens, demonstrates how the governmental structure, political philosophy, and gender roles affected and were affected by the overall society organization. As Aristotle wrote, "Man is a political animal by nature," though what was meant by being fully political differed radically. The law and the politics in the two civilizations were tools to create order, legitimize authority, and forge group identity. With the study of these two great differences and similar systems, the contradictions, incorporations, and exclusions, which constituted ancient political life are clarified.

The Mauryan monarchy and Athenian democracy are compared in this essay to discuss how the systems of governance were influenced by administration structures, political beliefs, and gender roles.

Administrative Structures State Power and Expansion

One of the most advanced bureaucracies in the ancient past was formed by the Mauryan Empire (c. 322-185 BCE) under the leadership of rulers such as Chandragupta and Ashoka. Based on the Arthashastra, attributed to Kautilya, the Mauryan government was centralized, vast and interfering. In his theory, Kautilya accepted a powerful central government with the support of its ministers, provincial governors, spies, and a permanent army to ensure domestic stability and an opportunity to expand (Black, 2011). The state controlled revenue collection, agricultural regulation and even economic production. This system of administration enabled the Mauryas to unify a large and mixed



Caption: Lion Capital of Ashoka, Samath-a representation of Mauryan ethos and Buddhist influenced politics.

region, uniting a multiplicity of language, ethnic, economic regions. The chief importance of efficient governance is highlighted by no one better than by Ashoka himself when he wrote:” All men are my children, and as I wish my children to be supplied with all welfare and happiness both here and hereafter, so I wish it to all men” (Rock Edict 6).

Athens in turn became a direct democracy that based its activities on Ekklesia (Assembly), Boule (Council) and other courts (Willis, 1996). Both women and men shared equal opportunities of making administrative decisions which were conducted by the men who took turns in the civic roles. Yet, the franchise was possible due to the size of Athens and use of slave labour and metics (foreigners who resided in the territory). Although effective to a city-state, the Athenian bureaucracy did not provide the level of size and rank to engender empire-building such as the Mauryas. Athenian governance was conceived to be that of people by people rather than people by bureaucrats, but even then, this democratic attribute esoterically left out most of the population (women and slaves) (Black, 2011).



Caption: Athenian Ekklesia governor of priests debating civic affairs at the Pnyx, in Ancient times.

Additionally, the state control of farming and taxation led to the stability of the state since it provided economic surplus. Farming levels enabled the state to levy landowners, traders and finance infrastructure services, military and welfare activities. Economy and administration complemented each other, working toward imperial unity as well as presenting morally-based authority.

Although Athens was a democracy, the dominant group that constituted the majority of the political power was the elite or the wealthy male citizens who had leisure and wealth to engage in politics. Most of the administrative positions were created through lot, except significant military and financial jobs, which were monopolized by nobles. This brings out a contradiction in the democratic system wherein although it had espoused equality, it was in many instances under actual governance through the few who were privileged. In comparison with the Mauryan centralized hierarchy, the Athenian government looks more participatory at a superficial level, but was still based on systematic exclusion and elite manipulation. Although these two systems differ in the framework, their use of administration, as a tool that holds a position of power, is relevant to keep it and strengthen the power of the predominant social forces.

Political Ideology and Reason to Rule

The political ideology of the Mauryan empire was much influenced by Hindu and Buddhist tradition. First, the Arthashastra of Kautilya was a practical, even harsh policy of conducting government affairs, in the spirit of realpolitik and based on spying. This ideology changed drastically however through the reign of Ashoka. Ashoka became a follower of Buddhism following the Kalinga War and the reign of Ashoka became inseparable with the Buddhist ideas of compassion, non-violence, and duty. His Rock and Pillar Edicts were a way of spreading this new ideology as in it, he depicted a moral dimension of governance. According to Black (2011), we find that the directives of Ashoka point to a paradigm that dictates that man rule should be as ethical as possible modeled on dharma-righteous moral order binding both the political and the religious authority (pp. 65 67).

Ashoka was not just a political figure when it came to power. Being the universal ruler (or chakravartin) in Buddhist cosmology, he was not only a king but a model of other citizens. This

title highlighted his responsibility of upholding both ecological and social orderliness by use of Dhamma (righteous conduct). In the Major Rock Edict XIII, Ashoka criticizes violent conquest in preference to the so-called conquest by Dhamma (in which the king sheds not a drop of blood) by claiming, “The conquest of self and moral law was the greatest conquest.” His government also had Dhamma Mahamatras, who served as officials charged with ensuring moral, social welfare, and religious tolerance was practiced in his vast empire.

The imperial vision of Ashoka integrated morality and coaching. The moral teaching was transferred to the domain of governance, and the governance was shaped to be based on morality. Ethical rulership became an imperial doctrine as he applied his strategies of public inscriptions visible to the people in the centers of trade routes and cities. This combination of the state and spirituality was unequaled in the ancient world and showed the ways in which the government could provide culture as an unifying mechanism instead of military conquest.

The political ideology of Athens on the other hand focused on reasoned deliberation, civic virtue and citizen activity. The democratic spirit was constructed out of the involvement of free men citizens in the matters of legislation and the judge. It was, however, based on Greek philosophical traditions particularly that of Plato and Aristotle. Aristotle, specifically, promoted politeia or a mixed constitution, whose combinations of oligarchy and democracy he believed to be the most secure governor (Black, 2011). Nonetheless, Athenian democracy was a restricted entity in spite of its ideals. The political cycle was a theory put forward by Aristotle concerning the transition of pure democracies into mob rule (ochlocracy), and he has said that the unstable nature of Athenian democracy was its inclination towards populism and demagoguery. These internal weaknesses coupled with external factors such as war and inequality in the economy, ultimately contributed to the diminishing of the democratic system. The transformation of oligarchy and later on autocracy ousted by Macedonian influence closed the Athenian democratic experiment.

In addition, political involvement was limited to a select group of men only. The conflict between philosophical rationality and social exclusion is expressed in the words of Aristotle himself, who once wrote, quote, “The male is clearly superior, and the female inferior; and the

one rules, and the other is subject” (Politics, Book I). Although Athens had the vision of a law which was founded on the agreement of reason, it occupied the reason on its own side in excluding the women, the slaves, and the foreigners.

Mauryan and Athenian systems can demonstrate the importance of political ideology that was significant to legitimize power and manner of governance structure. In Mauryan India, the Buddhism ideology driven by Ashoka had classified the moral power to the core centre of the administration. He had combined Dhamma and statecraft in a form whereby the king received his authority through moral deportment and religious ideals. The ideological basis of the city of Athens consisted in civic rationality; however, the actual practice had been limited by structural disparities.

Athens relied upon civic identity where Ashoka resorted to moral suasion in acquiring the diversity in a large area of varied populations. Philosophical approaches to inclusion Ashoka The ideology of Ashoka encouraged the inclusion of all due to ethical unity; Athenian democracy ensured order based on selective participation and justification of inequalities through philosophy. Therefore, the Mauryan rule represented unity through moral unity, whereas Athenian democracy became self-destructive due to the narrow egalitarianism.

Ideology in both instances like a mirror and a mask reflecting the values of the ruling and concealed the internal conflicts in the system. Rather than neutralizing force, law and governance were a great instrument in the creation of a historical memory, which enabled the maintenance of imperial or civic dominance.

Position of Women and Gendered Power

The role of women in Mauryan India was greatly affected by Manusmriti or Laws of Manu that allowed patriarchal rules to become a part of the state ideology. Manusmriti V.148: “She should never think of living independently.” And the Manusmriti IX.2: “Day and night women remain to be supported by the males of their families”. These laws put a seal of inequality between men and women, categorizing women as mentally dependent individuals who lack their own personal

autonomy. These ideals were strengthened with epic Ramayana and particularly through the fire ordeal (Agni Pariksha) of Sita who needed to demonstrate her right to her purity to be welcomed by Rama after walking through fire. According to the epic, he says: “Protect me, O Agni, if I am pure.” Her ordeal was used as the standard of moral female virtue that is obedient, pure and sacrificial. Myth and law, combined with caste ideology, therefore, supported a rather rigid patriarchal social order (Doniger, 1991; Frawley, 2001).



Caption: Sita facing the Agni-pariksha—ritual purity revitalized via law and mythic patriarchy in the Mauryan patriarchal society.

In Athens also, the roles of gender were regulated by law and philosophy. Solon who is one of the early lawgivers of Athens developed a legal code which solidified the place of women as subjugated. Women were not allowed to own property in their name and were under the legal custody of men and they were not allowed to participate in politics. As Solon said: “A woman’s

best reputation is to be least talked about by men, whether in praise or blame” . His laws denied the women their rights to travel anywhere or perform any rituals publicly. He also had written: there is no woman who shall have over three garments and there is no woman who shall have over one bushel of food. Through these rules, women were reduced to household rooms and such regulations supported their absence in the social life. The rule by fellow-crazy, or the rule by peers, was pursued strongly in Athens, especially since political power was conceived as a male virtue, associated with logos (reason). The active disenfranchisement of women in a polity thought of as one concerned with philosophical questioning shows that the refusal to give women political power was not an optic or half baked thing, but rather an ideologically grounded rule in and of itself. In Politics, Aristotle asserted that women are even excluded because of the fact that they possess the deliberative part of the soul, but without authority (Shapiro, 1991; Cartledge, 2001).

Similarities exist between how both Manu and Solon were fundamental to the development of the legal and moral codes of their societies, as both incorporated gender inequality into legislation. The legal system of Manu had been so closely connected with the ways of religious order and cosmic order that it was challenging the role of subjugation of women without challenging the divine order of the universe. The laws of Solon, more secular, were no less binding and present the legitimate patriarchal norms under the pretext of democratic order. The exclusion of women in the two societies was not mere coincidences but critical to the operation of the political process. Both the Athenian democracy and the Mauryan monarchy had a social order that valued the authority of male and the dominance in the public sphere; ostracizing women to the periphery of these spheres. The ideological explanations, be it religious in India and philosophical in Greece pointed out the larger role of law as an instrument of control not merely administration of justice. Manu and Solon illustrate to us how the initial law was very much part of the power structure of those times. They exuded and supported an image of society, in which gender roles were fixed, hierarchical and justified by appeals to tradition, religion, or civic stability. These laws indicate the extent to which the role of governance in the state of the ancient world was also much concerned with sustaining hierarchies, rather than just managing the state, as such.

Conclusion

The comparison between the Mauryan monarch and the Athenian democracy has revealed that politics was concerned not only with law and order but also with ideology and identity. Mauryan imperialism with Ashoka combined Buddhist morality and administrative control to create an imperial vision in which good and power walked together. Athens, on the contrary, had a system of exclusionary citizenship and a patriarchal order, which had a philosophical and legal culture to support it, even though it was a state with democratic intentions.

The two societies, although not dissimilar in structure, applied their political ideologies to preserve boot and manage challenges. The Dhamma of Ashoka encouraged unity by means of moral governance, whereas Athens depended on selective engagements on the basis of civic virtue and intuitive deliberation. Nonetheless, inequality, particularly gender based, became sanctioned in each of the systems in its statement of basic laws, which illustrated how governments tended to solidify the prevailing hierarchy. The Arthashastra states, "Welfare of the people is his own welfare and the king must cause welfare of the people." Likewise, Pericles once explained that our constitution is termed as a democracy since power does not rest on a minority and the people as whole. Nevertheless, they both conceal the omissions that supported these systems- be it on grounds of caste, gender, or class.

Finally, during ancient times, the political process was not impartial. It was an influential ideological project grounded in the assembly and the maintenance of systems of control, social norms embedded in place, and a means of justification on religious, philosophical, and legal fronts. By investigating the ways in which ancient empires and democracies ruled, new ideas are obtained regarding how contemporary systems still find their way through the intricate members of power, ethical, inclusive, and just.

References

- Black, A. (2011). A World History of Ancient Political Thought: Its Significance and Consequences. Oxford University Press. gender roles shaped and reflected systems of governance.
- Cartledge, P. (2001). The Greeks: A Portrait of Self and Others. Oxford University Press.
- Doniger, W. (1991). The Laws of Manu. Penguin Classics.
- Frawley, D. (2001). The Sacred Books of the East: Ancient Indian Vedic Traditions. Tradition Institute.
- Shapiro, H. A. (1991). Women in Ancient Greece. British Museum Press.
- Willis, R. (1996). World Mythology: The Illustrated Guide. Holt Paperbacks.